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Javon Jackson Part II
(The Covid Interview)

The Covid-19 pandemic impacted the music and arts community particularly hard. Musicians who had previously been interviewed for the Fillius Jazz Archive graciously shared their experiences during this virtual shutdown period. The political and racial unrest occurring simultaneously was also addressed.

Javon was interviewed via Zoom on June 3, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. I'm happy to have Javon Jackson remotely with me today. It's been almost ten years since we last had an interview when you were at Hamilton College, and can you sum up those ten years?

JJ: Well time goes fast, first thing. Since then a lot has occurred. I'm now living in Connecticut, I'm the chair of the Jackie McLean Institute of Jazz at the University of Hartford. So now I live in the State of Connecticut, where at that time I was living in New Jersey. So things are going good. I've had a lot of great opportunities that have been afforded to me and still enjoy a performance career, although performing right now is on a hiatus for many of us, all of us. So with that, the ten years have been good.

MR: Did you, as the head of the school, the jazz department, have a say in what methods you would try to keep working with the students when everyone had to vacate campus?

JJ: Right. It was basically a university mandate that everything would occur online. So we took on that same process like most universities and institutions are doing throughout the United States.

MR: What's your experience been with it? Has it been difficult?

JJ: I found it to be okay actually in a one-on-one situation where you're doing private lessons it's much the same except that individual is not in the same room as you. But beyond that we're still able to have conversations. They're able to play something. I'm able to give a response in terms of some feedback or support, and we can still develop with coursework. There's a business course that I teach that is not necessarily a problem because we have Zoom in this same manner, and one person is normally speaking at a time. The tough situation comes when it pertains to ensembles where we're used to having everyone perform together, interact in real time, interface, have conversation, definitely very difficult because now you're in a situation where someone has to play something and then that might get layered on top, almost like in the way if you're doing a

recording out in a studio. But the students aren't necessarily able to grasp that interaction that you feel when you're presenting as a group, in person.

MR: Yes, do you — this would be like looking into the future — do you anticipate that there might be more emphasis on using this even when it's not necessary?

JJ: Well I mean definitely for health reasons, until there's a vaccine for what we're currently going through, there's going to have to be a way for us to find the opportunity for students to get the best experience they can through this platform. So whether it means having a pre-recorded rhythm section, bass, drums and piano or guitar as part of that rhythm section, and they create the bottom if you will, or the palette for the rest of the composition. It might have to occur like that for a while. I'm sure, there are certain platforms I'm told where you're actually able to play at the same time with headphones and very much in the same way as if you're in a studio. I just haven't become acutely aware of them to be able to implement them myself, but my guess is if it has to happen in the next month or so I'll do some research, and the students are probably so far ahead of me they're aware of how this can occur anyway.

MR: Yeah. Sometimes the little bit of experience I had with it finishing a semester was comical because sometimes the students on the other end would be talking me through the tech issues and I suppose it's a good learning experience for us that aren't that familiar with it or comfortable.

JJ: Right.

MR: As far as loss of gigs and concerts, did your cancellations come all at once or did you sort of see it coming and how did you feel about it when certain engagements you had lined up —

JJ: Right, well they came, Monk, as a trickling in the beginning, certain concerts month by month and then there was just several months regarding to the summer just all being cancelled. My reaction is I can't get mad because everyone is experiencing this, whether in the sports arena, in the performance arena, Broadway theater. So it's not as if it's an isolated thing against me, the lone wolf jazz saxophonist, just for everyone. So I just have to kind of accept it and use this opportunity to find some other things to do which — I had a conversation with Sonny Rollins about this situation by phone and he said, "Remember there's always a lot to do in the house." And he is so right. I mean there's so much actually that you can do when you're inside, is what he said to me. So trying to take advantage of that with some reading. Actually I've been revisiting so many CDs and recordings that I've had time to look at and obviously you can put more time in with your music and try to hone that skill or that craft, and maybe some compositions, some writing. And then again, just try to keep yourself ready for the opportunities when they

will come back. But never have I gotten upset about it, because again, everyone is involved in it. Every sect of life.

MR: Yes. And I know some musicians that, when those things first started to come trickling in they were posting things on FaceBook or whatever that almost sounded like they were being singled out, the way they were speaking like. But as you say, everybody is in the same position. So have you, how far ahead have people cancelled?

JJ: Well let me see, 'cause interestingly enough I went to Thailand twice in January. I went in the early part of January and I went at the end of January into early February. And then I played — no that's not true. I went to Thailand in late January and late February into March. And so I got back March 2 and I haven't played a concert since. So I was due to play the Saratoga Jazz Festival this year, that's been cancelled of course, the festival; the San Jose Jazz Festival, that's been postponed to next year; various venues that I was going to be playing at, there was a concert/festival I've been doing in Arizona, Prescott, Arizona got cancelled. So it's just been a slew of performances, concerts, college performances at Michigan State University. There was just so many different things. But most all of them actually have been either postponed or — well not, postponed and the date has gone along with that postponement. And so all we can do from there is see how it turns out for the next year.

MR: I'm assuming that for some of these things you had engaged sidemen, sidepeople, and that then you have to make that phone call to them. How did that feel?

JJ: Well again, we're all experiencing it and I'm not the only one that's getting the phone call or giving the phone call. They're getting phone calls from multiple people so there's a certain amount of understanding. Again this is in territory that none of us have ever been in before. So we just sit and we kind of commiserate about the situation, we find a way to have some laughter before we get off the phone and we just kind of press on and hope for the best and just wait for that opportunity to perform.

MR: Yeah. I had one experience where the venue — it is a fairly small venue — and the person called me up and asked me, "Well what do you think? Do you want to do it?" And it was the first time that had happened, I think about the only time. And I wasn't sure what to say because I was unprepared to make the call myself and I had four other people that I was basically — would have been affected by it. Did you have to cancel anything yourself, or have the opportunity?

JJ: Did I have the opportunity to cancel any gig that I had?

MR: Yes.

JJ: Well there were a lot of my gigs I got to call and then I would inform the musicians. I mean actually today one of the band members said, "I guess Saratoga" — Saratoga was going to be June 25 or 27 of this year, at the end of this month. And they said, "I guess

Saratoga is cancelled, right?" I said, "Yes." So sometimes I didn't make the call because I just assumed that everyone thought everything has been cancelled. But then some people were still holding out with some sense of hope that it would occur. But I've made some calls but mostly it wasn't going to happen so — all the clubs have been closed. So there's no reason for somebody to be saying are we going to be playing at this club, because all the clubs are closed. So it means there's no concert, or no performance.

MR: Have you taken up any non-musical activities that you would never have pictured doing?

JJ: Never pictured doing. I've never been a major TV watcher but I found myself watching some series or doing more watching of documentaries on TV, those have been good for me. I just watched Chisholm '72 about Shirley Chisholm and her run for the presidency. Obviously I was a young guy then so that was great. And so now I need to again get some books back out, some novels, and read, which is something I used to do a lot but sometimes you get busy and you get away from that. So in that way it's been kind of an opportunity to reset a little bit.

MR: I remember from our interview almost ten years ago you seemed to be a person that has your goals pretty well set up. At least you mentioned a bunch of things that were goals for you and how do you put goals in place at this particular time, and what could they be?

JJ: Wow I just feel like there's some goals that I have not moved. In other words I've got goals I want to attain so it puts a little more pressure on me just to find a way to attain the goal during this situation. Some, like this recording project I'm going to be getting started on but because we're not able to get in the studio, we're not able to rehearse, things like that, that has pushed back that particular goal. But some goals can still be — that can still be something that I can look toward without making any change in terms of that day that I have in place to attain those goals. So if you say you will lose ten pounds in the next three weeks there's nothing stopping me from that. If I want to make sure I ride the exercise bike five days a week there's nothing stopping me from that, right? So there's still certain things that actually I have a better opportunity to get to those because I'm in the home. Because that's what I find, to me I nibble a lot. You're in the house and you just feel like you're nibbling all the time. And before you know it because you're not leaving the house and you're nibbling and you're sitting and you're not necessarily moving. So I bought an exercise bike. I had one before, then I got another exercise bike a couple of years ago and that's been good. I still have a regimen getting up, on the bike, watch some television at the same time. Things like that that keep me, as you said, on a certain kind of schedule. It's important to try to keep a schedule.

MR: There was a week, I guess it was around the end of March, where it seemed like every other day one of our influential musicians, we were reading obituaries. And it was very sad and I wondered if you have lost any close musician friends?

JJ: Several. Jimmy Heath was a very close friend and mentor. Jimmy passed. Jimmy Cobb was a very close friend and mentor. He just passed recently. McCoy Tyner was someone I had been working with over the last two, three years, he passed. Wallace Roney, who was a bandmate and good friend and someone I learned an immense amount from, he passed. Musicians in Denver that I knew have passed, a couple, and obviously the Marsalis family, Delfeayo was someone I went to college with, the passing of his father, you feel sadness there and some other colleagues that I have a close relationship with that have lost a parent too. So right, that has been, and also there has not been an opportunity to have a celebration either through a funeral or a memorial because there's no opportunity to see these individuals or other individuals, we could gather to celebrate their life. So that's been a bit of a challenge and unfortunate. So right, this, some of it hits close. No question about it.

MR: Yeah somehow I had to correct myself — I knew Bucky Pizzarelli pretty well and he had been to Hamilton many times, and when he passed away I just felt like that's not fair somehow, that this took him down even though he was in poor health. And I had to stop myself and say it's not fair for anybody that's losing — it's not just musicians it's across the board as you had said.

JJ: Right. I forgot to mention Lee Konitz, a person I'm very fond of and a mentor as well. There's been so many, you're right, in some ways it doesn't seem fair, but at the same time I think that it might not be wise for me to question so much as opposed to appreciating that time and that person and that spirit, and allow that to be something that I can surround myself and put my arms around that as opposed to why this person and why not this person, and why this person. Because everyone is going through something of that nature, whether we know it or not. So I really work on trying not to make that my business in terms of why them, or what's fair and what isn't fair.

MR: Yeah. Let me return to the academic situation for a moment. I'm wondering if you've had an added role of trying to stay in touch with students and so forth, to just see how they're doing and do you get a sense of how they're being affected by this?

JJ: Sure. What happens too, a lot of students reach out, they'll send a text, "Professor how are you?" I'll get an email, thinking about you, and then obviously with the passing of some of the musicians I used to work with and had friendships with the students are aware of that so I get a lot of emails from them as well. It's very interesting. They're trying to figure this out, they'll want to know what does their future look like for the fall for the university which we're still in a holding pattern as this is taping in terms of how we're going to go back. The plan is to go back, in person, at the beginning of school which would be late August, but that could change where it could be on another kind of an online kind of situation platform that could occur on some levels. As you know, some

schools, like Notre Dame, are starting pretty quickly, as early as they can in August, to try to get it all in before Thanksgiving. So that's what they're trying anyway. So again I try to case-by-case students that are thinking about coming to the University of Hartford, Jackie McLean Institute of Jazz, they're interested to know what's going on and obviously all I can let them know is what I receive from the university because I don't really know. But you're right, there's a lot of questions from faculty, from administration, and it's a lot of not knowing.

MR: This is just an aside but I'm reading a book about the bassist Pops Foster and in the book he talks about playing on the steamboat lines on the Mississippi and in 1917 we had to shut down for a couple of months because of the flu. I said wow. That was over a hundred years ago and the same type of thing happened to musicians and everyone at that time.

JJ: Right. Like they say at some point things kind of come and you can almost kind of point your finger in the history of time when there's been an occurrence similar. And so we're living through it in our lifetimes.

MR: It makes me wonder if historians or even ten years from now, when they think of the spring of 2020, we already had a political crisis going on, at least in my estimation, and we have a pandemic, and now we have this racial crisis spawned by this incident in Minneapolis. And I don't have a question here I guess I'm just wondering if you think that this particular time will result in some significant change.

JJ: I think that this most recent situation, murder of George Floyd, has ignited in a way that I've never seen, and even if you look at a lot of the protests, and most of all I've found all the protests in the past that have erupted from cities have been because of the police or the killing of a black person. So you see it over in parts of Europe or London, so it has really spread in a way that you would have never seen it before. And I think that some of the things I'm seeing — I saw something last night on the road or bridge in Portland, Oregon, they just laid on the ground and took up the whole bridge, and the fact that the other protests if you will, they were largely African-American or black people. Now you are seeing there is an interracial group. It's not all just — there's a lot of white people involved that are marching that really feel outraged and it's really getting the attention of a lot of people, where there's more meaningful conversation to understand what Javon, for example, do you experience racism every day? Absolutely. You think about things in a different way and so it's finally — the powder keg has really popped and so we really have to have a conversation in a way you can really get to understanding, well Javon had never been stopped over by the police possibly because you're black. Well I was sitting in a parking lot some years ago in New Jersey, in Fawn Park, New Jersey. I was to meet my wife at a Trader Joe's. We were going to meet at noon but I was early, I got there

about 11:30, 11:35, and within about three minutes, five minutes, someone knocked on my windshield. And I looked to my left, it was a policeman. He said, "I'm just getting a response from one of the stores in this area" it was like a little mall, "that you've been sitting here for a few minutes. Could I ask why?" I said, "Well it's really none of your business." He says, "Well I want to see your driver's license and registration." So I had a couple of choices. Because we always have a choice. I could make a big deal out of it or I could show him what he wants. Well here's the thing, okay Javon Jackson's in a Mercedes. Really? That's basically what it was. It this his car? Let's find out, is it stolen? And so I handed him the driver's license and registration. Of course it checked out, he handed it back. So I always laugh, that wasn't even a driving while black. That was, I was parked, that's something that you would never have to go through. No one would see you in a Mercedes and question if it's your car. So these kinds of things happen all the time, regularly.

MR: And it reminds me of the Ruth Brown story. She had a band, they had good cars, and the state troopers just couldn't understand it, why she would have a good car like that.

JJ: Right.

MR: Well that's distressing. I don't know if you have any thoughts about how that gets changed. How do you legislate a change in attitude, or make people more aware?

JJ: Well again, almost anybody you can speak to a black person has had some kind of common occurrence like that, where you walk into an elevator and there's a white person, a woman, older or possibly maybe elderly, who kind of clutched her bag. Or there's always maybe a sense that you're looked upon as a certain class per se unless in certain situations unless you maybe dress the part. I mean I've always kind of felt sometimes if I'm going into — I used to, not so much now but still possibly — but going into a certain situation. Well I've got to make sure I have a sport coat on and nice pair of shoes, so they know that I'm supposed to be here. Right? But of course I'm supposed to be here, I'm an American. I'm a human being. But there is that, sometimes quote unquote paranoia, but sometimes it's not paranoia it's very real. But sometimes to the degree I would make it real all the time leads into possibly my paranoia. So I work as hard as I can to have a case by case basis. I've been fortunate as a musician to have experienced what I call the great equalizer, and that is to travel all over the world. So I've been able to travel, see things, and as I see things I get to learn that it is not every white person is racist. But every once in a while things will happen where a person might get familiar. Like if you take the Joe Biden statement where he said if you're not voting for me you ain't black. Well the history is that we vote Democratic. But more than that he just got familiar. Or because someone said he's racist. No he got familiar, he must have black friends so he made an assumption. So I think a lot of times it's getting to the point where actually you can start

to look at that and find out where we can start, day one, move it forward but also realize the history of what we've experienced as black people shapes those communities. So what's wrong with taking 50 million dollars, 60 million dollars, and stacking it back into those communities. And people say oh well we can't do reparations. Wait a minute, some of these people from the time that we've had Reconstruction forward have never really had a shot. So they came out of slavery and just generations and generations have never actually even been given a shot for real. And that is what we talk about the disparity. The Kerner Commission, which was written what in 1967 or 8? And what did it say? Two societies, one black, one white, unequal. Right? So at some point there has to be some kind of attention to try to make the disparity somewhat equal. But everyone, despite that, people can come out of a neighborhood like that, I mean not so, I'm sorry, a neighborhood that is not so properly set up and you could still have a LeBron James. You could still have so many. And you could have maybe a white community that has the best of everything and you could still have a person that doesn't ascend the way they want to ascend. But I think the idea will be to try to get more of a level playing field. But definitely when it comes to in general and not wholeheartedly but the respect that the police will have for African-Americans and there does always seem to be a sense that African-American is guilty immediately. So I mean this whole situation with George Floyd where there was a perception that he was passing a counterfeit bill. Okay well did he make the bill? I mean did someone give it to him and he's merely passing it on that way? But it never even got to that. So this is the presumption, the presumption of guilt before he's able actually — I mean I have a son around the same age as Ahmaud Arbery, who was just jogging, okay? He stopped for a moment, he saw a home that was not built, it was being built, and he decided to look at it, go in and look at the construction of it. What's so wrong with that? But he can't do that. And you know, so these are the kinds of things that have to come up, and I think if we're going to do it, since the powder keg has been popped, let's really try to go in and see what kind of meaningful change — because it's obvious that something's going on with this many people for years and years and years and years are falsely accused, or die or are mistreated. It's time for a change.

MR: I hope that, I think Biden said this is a wake up call. You'd think there's been lot of wake up calls before, I'm hoping that this indeed will be one.

JJ: Right. Legislation. There needs to be some legislation. Let's legislate about it. And from there we'll start to see. And I think what's important, someone mentioned this, to have more of the police in a sense reflect the communities that they're from and let them work in the communities by which they live so people can have a chance to have relationships with their policemen.

MR: Okay. I really appreciate you sharing that with me. Just to wrap up, I'm trying to think how to phrase this question. Are there things that you do, or were doing before the pandemic, that took a lot of time and energy, that you might not return to when things hopefully get back to normal?

JJ: I probably won't be sitting around as much. I've never been a big TV watcher. I like sports but I've never — so I've probably watched more TV now than I would normally. But this has been good because I'm allowed to connect with the family and watch some things with my wife and spend some time in those moments, so it's allowed me to kind of have a reset and do some things like that, so take advantage of those moments. Because as time moves on you don't get to do those things. Yeah. So I think stuff like that, or I'm washing a lot of dishes. So I mean, which I did that anyway, but I'm home and available so a lot of home things that I am able to be a part of. So I would say something like that. But in general I've tried to keep my life as much the same as it was before things have started to happen. I don't think I've changed my style too much.

MR: Okay. Well I appreciate your time today. I think your stories and opinions are very valuable for us to have. And I hope things return for you and for all of us. And you need to be out there performing for yourself and for us. So I look forward to that.

JJ: Yeah I appreciate you — it would be back to come back up in that area by the school. You've got some good restaurants up there and you've got a great campus. I talked to Dr. Woods after we spoke the other day so we're trying to plan a way for a visit up there, a residency or something. So it will be nice to get back out.

MR: Very good. I'd be happy to assist in that.

JJ: Yes sir.

MR: Okay Javon, thanks a lot.

JJ: Okay. Thanks, Monk.

MR: Bye-bye.